(INDIA) constituents—on board, but the Hooda camp vehemently opposed any such move.

There's no doubt that Hooda has successfully channelised Jat resentment against the BJP rule—a phase of mutual belligerence that saw the violent quota agitation of 2016, waves of farmer protests and, more recently, the wrestlers' stir in Delhi—into votes for the Congress. According to a Lokniti-CSDS (Centre for the Study of Developing Societies) post-poll survey, the Congress's support among Jats jumped from 33 per cent in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls to 64 per cent this year. The support of this agrarian community is determinative in some 37 of Haryana's 90 assembly seats.

THE CONGRESS LEADERSHIP FEARS THAT AGGRESSIVELY BACKING HOODA COULD LEAD TO COUNTER-POLARISATION AMONG OTHER COMMUNITIES

To make the most of it, the Congress has fielded Olympian Vinesh Phogat—a leading face of the protest against former Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) president and BJP leader Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh—from the Jat-dominated Julana constituency. Insiders claim the push came from Hooda. Not just that, Hooda has also helped the Congress make inroads into the BJP's non-Jat rainbow coalition, evident from the saffron party's declining support among the Other Backward Classes (OBCs)—from 74 per cent to 44 per cent, according to the survey cited earlier.

The BJP is trying hard to fight anti-incumbency, having dropped 15 of its 41 MLAs. The Congress, on the other hand, has declared a rerun for its 28 sitting MLAs. And most of them swear by Hooda. Among them, Rao Dan Singh (Mahendragarh), Dharam Singh Chhoker (Samalkha) and Surender Panwar (Sonipat) are in the crosshairs of the Enforcement Directorate and Mamman Khan (Ferozepur Jhirka) was arrested for his alleged role in the Nuh riots last year. They all got the party ticket, say insiders, because of Hooda's backing. The former CM's critics allege that he has teamed up with the AICC in-charge of Haryana, Deepak Babaria, to keep his intra-party rivals in check. Nevertheless, Selja, too, has managed to secure tickets for her loyalists, be it Pardeep Chaudhary (Kalka) or Shamsher Singh Gogi (Assandh).

Besides Selja, Rajya Sabha MP Randeep Surjewala, 57, too, is inimical to Hooda. To strengthen their post-poll bids for CM's chair, both MPs were pushing hard to contest from their respective bastions of Uklana (Hisar) and Kaithal (Kurukshetra). Even other MPs, including Hooda's son Deepender, expressed their desire to fight the election and kept the political pot boiling. Amid a lack of consensus, the declaration of candidates went on till the last day of filing the nominations on September 12. Finally, while Surjewala's son Aditya got the nod from Kaithal, quite a few from both Hooda's and Selja's camps also made the cut. Though Selja has been denied a ticket, she can take comfort in the fact that in 2005, Hooda was Rohtak MP when he was made to resign and take over the state's reins as CM. ■

J&K/ ILTIJA MUFTI

THE NEW-GEN MUFTI

By Moazum Mohammad
in Bijbehara

It has been close to 60 years now, but Fatima's political loyalties have never wavered. A devoted supporter of Mufti Mohammad Sayeed, she vividly recalls the first time the late chief minister won from Bijbehara in Anantnag district–in the 1967 assembly election, 33 years before he founded the Peoples Democratic Party. Now battling multiple age-related health issues, the nonagenarian still lives with the memories of the Mufti having lunch at their home. "I never feel old when I vote for the Muftis," says Fatima sitting on her porch, a few metres away from the shrine of Hazrat Baba Naseeb-ud-din Ghazi in a narrow alley of Bijbehara. The Muftis hail from a family of clerics and have a spiritual association with the shrine adjacent to their ancestral home.

Bijbehara is part of the Rajouri-Anantnag Lok Sabha constituency, and Fatima's vote this time had naturally gone to the late leader's daughter Mehbooba Mufti. She lost, though. "*Haar jeet chune masle* (Win or lose is not a criterion). They gave us roads, piped water and jobs. *Soun vote te dua chu yeman seet. Wan chu asee panin kor kamyaab karin. Tamis chu yete matamaal.* (Our vote and prayers

ILTIJA MUFTI FEELS HER VOICE CAN ADD WEIGHT TO PUBLIC ISSUES EVEN IN AN ASSEMBLY WITH TRUNCATED POWERS